AWESOME CYBER SECURITY HEAVEN · REALM DOSSIER · 2026 EDITION

The Bastion

Hardening & Defensive Infrastructure Tools

34	187,862	85%	26
FREE TOOLS	COMBINED STARS	ON GITHUB	ACTIVE IN 2026

34 tools · ← Back to the main list · Data verified **2026-10-22** (re-verified monthly)

CURATOR'S NOTES

Lock it down before they get in — auditing, hardening and host/network defense tooling.

MAINTENANCE SNAPSHOT (2026-10-22)

- **Active in the last 30 days:** 19 of 29 tracked GitHub repos (66%)
- **Part of Awesome Cyber Security Heaven** — 509 curated free tools across 14 realms

FLAGSHIP PICKS — THE HEAVYWEIGHTS

TOOL	★ STARS	CREATED	LAST PUSH	WHAT IT DOES
Fail2ban	18.8k	2011	2026-10-10 ✅	Daemon to ban hosts that cause multiple authentication errors
Lynis	16.5k	2013	2026-09-16	Lynis - Security auditing tool for Linux, macOS, and UNIX-based systems. Assists with compliance testing (HIPAA/ISO27001...
CrowdSec	15.2k	2020	2026-10-21 ✅	Open-source IDS/IPS, WAF and bot detection for Linux, Windows, Docker and Kubernetes, with a crowdsourced blocklist of m...
OpenVPN	14.7k	2012	2026-10-22 ✅	OpenVPN is an open source VPN daemon
GoPhish	14.3k	2013	2024-09-23 ⏳	Open-Source Phishing Toolkit
OpenSnitch	14.2k	2017	2026-07-26	OpenSnitch is a GNU/Linux interactive application firewall inspired by Little Snitch.

Full Inventory — 34 curated tools

ranked by GitHub adoption · 2026-10-22 census · non-GitHub entries listed last

TOOL	★ STARS	CREATED	LAST PUSH	LICENSE / TIER
Fail2ban	18.8k	2011	2026-10-10 ✅	— the classic log-watching IPS that bans brute-forcing IPs; still the default answer on every Linux server. Used by sysadmins on millions of servers to stop brute force; the classic free guard no commercial tool needed to replace. (GPL-2.0)
Lynis	16.5k	2013	2026-09-16	— agentless system auditing and hardening with CIS/PCI-DSS-aligned findings; runs anywhere in minutes. Used by system auditors running CIS-style hardening checks; the open-source alternative to commercial compliance scanners for Linux/Unix hosts. (GPL-3.0)
CrowdSec	15.2k	2020	2026-10-21 ✅	— collaborative behavior-detection engine with a global IP-reputation network; the modern Fail2ban, 60x faster and IPv6-ready. Used by server administrators and hosting providers; the open-source, crowdsourced alternative to commercial WAF and bot-management services.
OpenVPN	14.7k	2012	2026-10-22 ✅	— the industry-standard open-source VPN daemon for site-to-site and remote-access tunnels. Used by IT teams everywhere; the open-source alternative to commercial VPN gateways. (GPL-2.0 core, component exceptions)
GoPhish	14.3k	2013	2024-09-23 ⏳	— open-source phishing-simulation platform: launch awareness campaigns and measure exactly who clicks (community edition). Used by security awareness teams running phishing simulations; the open-source alternative to commercial awareness platforms like KnowBe4.
OpenSnitch	14.2k	2017	2026-07-26	— interactive application firewall (Little Snitch for Linux): allow/deny every outbound connection per process. Used by Linux power users and admins wanting per-application firewall control; the open equivalent of Little Snitch on macOS. (GPL-3.0)
Vuls	12.3k	2016	2026-10-21 ✅	— agentless vulnerability scanner for servers and containers, with CVE reporting across Linux and FreeBSD fleets. Used by server admins for agentless vulnerability scanning; the open-source alternative to Nessus for host patch audits. (GPL-3.0)
BunkerWeb	11.1k	2019	2026-10-21 ✅	— next-gen open WAF built on nginx: HTTPS, bot mitigation and network protections on by default. Used by web admins wanting a next-gen open-source WAF in front of their sites; the self-hosted alternative to Cloudflare's managed WAF. (AGPL-3.0)
testssl.sh	9.2k	2014	2026-10-21 ✅	— command-line TLS/SSL configuration auditor: protocols, ciphers, chains, vulnerabilities, grading — no agent required. Used by TLS auditors and pentesters everywhere; the free command-line alternative to Qualys SSL Labs for server-side TLS grading. (GPL-2.0)
ClamAV	7.4k	2012	2026-08-27	— the open-source antivirus engine that powers mail gateways and file-screening pipelines everywhere. Used on countless mail gateways and Linux file screens; the AV engine many commercial mail filters embed. (GPL-2.0)
Fleet	7k	2020	2026-10-22 ✅	— osquery fleet management: device visibility and policy enforcement at scale, open core with a free tier. Used by IT and security teams managing osquery fleets at scale; the open-source alternative to commercial device management and EDR consoles. (MIT, open core)
dev-sec hardening collection	5.5k	2015	2026-10-13 ✅	— battle-tested Ansible roles for OS, SSH, nginx and MySQL baselines; hardening as code. Used by DevOps teams enforcing server baselines as code; the open-source alternative to commercial configuration-compliance agents.
OSSEC	5.1k	2013	2026-10-21 ✅	— the original open-source HIDS: log analysis, file integrity and rootkit detection (Wazuh's ancestor). Used by SOC teams on a budget for host intrusion detection; the veteran open HIDS that predates commercial EDR. (GPL-2.0)
OPNsense	4.8k	2014	2026-10-21 ✅	— open-source firewall/router distro with IDS, VPN and reporting — a pfSense successor built on HardenedBSD. Used by network administrators as a full open-source firewall/router; the business-ready free alternative to commercial UTM appliances. (BSD-2)
ssh-audit	4.3k	2017	2026-10-17 ✅	— SSH server configuration auditor: algorithms, keys and best-practice flags in one run. Used by server hardening teams to audit SSH configurations and algorithms; the standard free SSH auditor. (GPL-3.0)

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OpenSSH	4.1k	2014	2026-10-18 ✅	— the world's default secure remote-access suite: encrypted shells, tunnels and key management. Used on virtually every Linux server on earth; the open standard for secure remote access that commercial SSH servers complement, not replace. (BSD-style)
Coraza	3.9k	2020	2026-10-21 ✅	— ModSecurity-compatible WAF engine in Go; the actively developed successor for OWASP CRS deployments. Used by platform teams embedding a WAF engine inside Go services.
OWASP Core Rule Set	3.3k	2020	2026-10-22 ✅	— the world's most-deployed WAF ruleset; battle-tested protection for web servers, tuned for ModSecurity and Coraza. Used by WAF administrators on nginx, Apache and Coraza; the free ruleset protecting more sites than most commercial WAF feeds.
OpenRASP	3k	2017	2025-10-02 ⏳	— runtime application self-protection: instrument the app itself so attacks get blocked from the inside. Used by AppSec teams adding runtime self-protection to apps; the open-source alternative to commercial RASP vendors.
ComplianceAsCode content	2.8k	2014	2026-10-22 ✅	— the open SCAP/Baseline rule corpus for RHEL, Ubuntu and friends; the content that powers OpenSCAP-style audits. Used by compliance and platform teams applying SCAP hardening profiles; the open-source ruleset commercial compliance products build on.
checksec.sh	2.4k	2014	2026-09-24 ✅	— one-shot binary hardening audit: NX, canaries, PIE, RELRO and fortify flags in a single run. Used by exploit developers and binary auditors checking hardening mitigations; the standard free one-liner for this job. (BSD-3-Clause)
Neo23x0 auditd config	2k	2018	2026-05-04	— Florian Roth's hardened auditd rule set: the Linux logging baseline used across incident-response teams. Used by blue teams hardening Linux audit collection; the widely-forked open auditd baseline behind many SOC deployments. (Apache-2.0)
open-appsec	1.7k	2022	2026-09-06	— ML-driven prevention engine that stops OWASP Top 10 and zero-day web attacks without signatures. Used by security teams deploying machine-learning WAF protection; an open-source alternative to commercial ML-based WAF products.
SELinux	1.6k	2014	2026-10-16 ✅	— mandatory access control for Linux: policy-based confinement that survives a compromised application. Used by hardened enterprise Linux deployments; the mandatory access control standard in RHEL-family distributions. (GPL-2.0)
shellfirm	949	2021	2026-05-15	— a pre-execution guard for your shell: challenges dangerous commands (rm -rf, kubectl delete) before they run. Used by engineers protecting themselves from dangerous commands; a lightweight open guardrail before your shell executes rm -rf. (Apache-2.0)
AIDE	757	2019	2026-09-22 ✅	— Advanced Intrusion Detection Environment: file-integrity monitoring that alerts the moment system files change. Used by hardening teams for file-integrity monitoring; the free open alternative to commercial FIM modules. (GPL-2.0)
stunnel	397	2015	2026-09-17	— universal TLS wrapper that adds encryption to any TCP service in minutes. Used by admins adding TLS to legacy services; the free universal TLS wrapper. (GPL-2.0)
Awesome WebSocket Security	315	2021	2022-01-10 ⏳	— curated research, tools and CVEs for WebSocket protocol security. Used by web pentesters studying WebSocket attack surface. (Apache-2.0, curated list)
unmask	5	2026	2026-10-21 ✅	— self-hosted privacy-first bot management gateway with verified-crawler bypass. Used by teams filtering bot traffic without third-party SaaS; the self-hosted bot-defense gateway. (Apache-2.0)
Netfilter/iptables	—	—	—	— the Linux kernel's native packet-filtering framework; the foundation every host firewall build starts from. Used by every Linux firewall admin; the kernel-level packet filter that commercial Linux firewalls wrap a UI around. (GPL-2.0)
OpenBSD PF	—	—	—	— the packet filter famous for correctness and readable rules; the syntax OpenBSD, pfSense and OPNsense share. Used by OpenBSD and firewall admins; the famously audited packet filter behind many security appliances. (ISC)
Qubes OS	—	—	—	— the security-by-compartmentalization desktop OS; " reasonably secure" by architecture, not by antivirus. Used by journalists, researchers and high-risk users; the compartmentalized security desktop with no commercial counterpart. (GPL-2.0)
SpamAssassin	—	—	—	— the veteran open-source spam filter; bayesian scoring and rule engine at the mail gateway. Used by mail administrators on countless gateways; the veteran open-source anti-spam engine many commercial filters license. (Apache-2.0)

TOOL	★ STARS	CREATED	LAST PUSH	LICENSE / TIER
Tor	—	—	—	— the anonymity network: routed egress through thousands of volunteer relays; the standard for privacy-preserving research access. Used by privacy-focused researchers, journalists and investigators; the free anonymity network with no commercial equivalent. (BSD-3-Clause)